

More on Dissertations

Outline

1. Different types of research question (review)
2. Different types of research design (review)
3. Different logics of evidence
4. Additional notes
5. Examples
6. Q&A if time

Different types of research question

$$x \rightarrow y$$

- “y-centered” questions
 - Explaining a puzzle; “causes of effects”
 - “Puzzle”: An (arguably) unexpected event or non-event; or an intriguing difference across cases.
 - Either actual variation (across cases) or implied variation (single case)
- “x-centered” questions
 - The impact of something on something else; “effects of causes”
- Incorporating some of each:
 - What theory or interpretation best characterizes a phenomena?

Different types of research question

- Avoid mere descriptions of events or policy areas, without the structure of clear research question with distinct potential answers.
- A good research question points towards the types of possible answers:
 - ✓ “Why did A happen in this case (, but B happen in another case)?” → explanations
 - ✓ “What was the effect of X on Y?” → impacts
 - ✓ “Is phenomena X better understood with theoretical approach A, B, or C?”
 - ✗ “What should policymakers do about X” → not empirical (unless comparing effectiveness of multiple existing approaches with x-centered questions)
 - ✗ “How does X play a role in Y?” → unclear unless theory provides contrasting answers
 - ✗ “How did X happen?” → purely descriptive unless clearly structured with competing hypotheses/explanations
 - ✗ “Why did X happen *and* what were its consequences?” → too much for one diss.!

Different types of research question

- A frequent situation: “I’m interested in [some policy/process/event] but don’t know what makes sense as an empirical research question!”
- Some first-order options to consider:
 - y-centered:
 - Why did this happen?
 - Why did it happen in case A but not in case B? (remember, “case” can be interpreted broadly)
 - Why did it happen in form A rather than in form B?
 - Why did the way that it happened vary from setting to setting?
 - x-centered:
 - What effect did it have on Y?
 - How did the effects that it had depend on intervening factor Z?
 - More complex:
 - Do theoretical approaches / conceptual apparatus A or B better help us understand how it works / how it happened / how individuals acted, etc.

Different types of research design

- Single case study
- Comparative case studies
- Quantitative study
- Survey-based study

Different types of research design

Single case study

- Can be a case of a policy, institution, episode, process, etc.
- Need to establish how the case is “puzzling;” or offers particular theoretical insight/importance.
 - E.g. because theory says it should not be like this; theory ignores this; theory is contentious; etc.
- Prerequisite: can you get beyond superficial information?
 - Access to people, documents, language, archives
- Common issues:
 - What is it a case of?
 - Ensuring evidence speaks to testing hypotheses/arguments, going beyond just description.
 - Sufficient access, language skills, understanding of context?

Different types of research design

Comparative case studies

- “Classic” two-country comparison (but need to establish comparability)
 - Sometimes three countries; more than that gets risky. Depth vs breadth.
- Within-country comparison (e.g. organizations, subnational units)
- Comparison over time (before-vs-after); across policy areas; or even across multiple instances of a specific dynamic.
- Ameliorates some burden of access: Compare on basis of publicly available data.
- Still need to establish why puzzling and/or important to study.
- Common issues: Differences obvious, or not as strong as supposed? Comparability? What does the comparison show you that you cannot get from a case study?

Different types of research design

Quantitative study

- Regression model, or sometimes “light” quant based on targeted descriptive stats.
- If you have data or can generate a dataset.
- Testing explanatory hypotheses or evaluating impact of one key indep var.
- Not likely possible to reach frontier of methodological sophistication, but must at least be able to speak to most obvious concerns (e.g. causality)
- Still requires theoretical grounding to generate expectations/hypotheses.
- Common issues:
 - Has it been done before? Do you have necessary technical skills? Do measures adequately capture concepts? Clarity of presentation?
- Not a problem: Null results (provided your study is well-designed)

Different types of research design

Survey-based study

- Usually focused on variation across individuals; or in individuals across different settings.
 - More rarely, focused on interpretation of qualitative responses.
 - Could also consider survey experiments with randomised vignettes.
- Must go beyond simply “what do people think about this?”
- Common issues
 - Questionnaire design; sample design; response rate; sample size.
 - Need ethics review approval.

Different logics of evidence

- Variational evidence
 - Quantitative; but also
 - Cross-case comparisons (including within-country or over-time comparisons)
 - e.g. if you want to explain differences in Y; can rule out possible explanatory factors where “value of X” is identical across cases. Explanation must also be something that varies.
- Within-case evidence
 - Specific facts and/or details of process can either be consistent or inconsistent with different hypotheses/models.
- Interpretive evidence
 - Asking people questions, the answers to which reveal their own interpretations in a way that helps distinguish between different hypotheses/models.
- Note that interviews could potentially be used to generate any of these three!
 - Interviews as source of information about **the respondent** vs. source of information about **the world**.
- Note that some dissertations combine across different logics of evidence; e.g. comparison plus process details; or within-case evidence plus long-form interviews.

A common dissertation structure

- Introduction
 - Identify and motivate the topic and the question
 - Really quick recap of theory and cases
 - Preview results (don't write dissertation as 'mystery novel')
- Theory
 - Starting principles/framework
 - Express the relationship of interest
 - Clearly state your primary explanation
 - Note most important alternatives
- Methods
 - Identify all relevant concepts
 - Motivate evidence (including case selection)
 - Explain strategy for data collection and analysis
- Analysis
 - Assess presence/absence of the observable implications of your theory
 - Engage with alternative explanations
 - For case studies, often need to choose between empirical or thematic organising framework
- Discussion/Conclusion
 - Summarize how cases stack up on key evidence
 - Implications for hypotheses and alternatives
 - (Optionally, policy implications)

Dissertation supervisors

- Dissertation supervisor is not your manager; they are there for advice/guidance especially on research question and research design.
- You do not need permission from a prospective supervisor to list them; nor is it up to them to be your supervisor or not!
- Potential supervisors:
 - Must be in Government Department
 - Most likely, but not necessarily, from among the below:
 - Elise Antoine
 - Daniel Berliner
 - Michael Lerner
 - Martin Lodge
 - Stefano Merlo
 - Ed Page
 - Cheryl Schonhardt-Bailey
 - *Jill Stuart (expert on comparative and global policy and regulation, especially new technology focus)*
 - Joachim Wehner
 - Elisa Wirsching

Other notes

- PPA relevance: Is any key concept (e.g. IV/DV) relevant to the decisionmaking, design, implementation, evaluation, or administration of any public policy?
- Beware difficulty of studying something that hasn't happened yet.
- Absolutely OK to base topic on expertise you already have (or want to gain) and/or where you expect to be during summer.
- Ethics review (if research will involve human subjects e.g. interviews or surveys)
- See MSc PPA examples on GV499 Moodle page (but don't treat them as too prescriptive)
- Some useful resources:
 - Booth *Craft of Research* (a broad introduction to how to think about structuring research and setting out arguments, written for arts and humanities, natural and social sciences)
 - Gerring *Social Science Methodology: A Unified Framework* (useful research methodology primer)

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- Note that all research questions have been paraphrased, summarized, and presented in abstract terms.
- Not all were Distinction:
 - Depends both on the setup and the execution!

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *What explains differences across (three countries in the same region) in the extent to which politicians promoted (specific policy innovation)?*
- Y-centered
- Establishes that the three countries are comparable to each other in this setting.
- Develops two rival theoretical perspectives from existing literatures
- Evidence from comparing policy development across the cases, based on primary and secondary documents (both variational and within-case evidence).

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *What is effect of (specific administrative change)(in specific sector in specific country) on PSM?*
- X-centered
- Quantitative survey, comparing PSM responses across (change) and (no-change) settings.
- Rival theoretical expectations drawn from relevant literature.

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *Does representation of women in police force lead to changes in public behavior or org. performance (in a specific country)?*
- X-centered
- Rival theoretical expectations drawn from relevant literature.
- Comparison across 15-20 police agencies, using both qual and quant information.

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *How do SLBs in (setting) use (specific technology) in working with clients?*
- Borderline too-descriptive question, but makes it work by clearly developing a novel theoretical perspective, and contrasting it with alternate perspectives from existing literature.
- Evidence from in-depth interviews across three different sites.
- Not easily categorized as either x- or y-centered.

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *Why do megaprojects fail? (In context of a specific project in a specific country)*
- Focused on testing one specific existing theoretical approach in answer to the big question.
 - Ideally involves some attention to rejecting alternative approaches.
- Y-centered (puzzle focused) but also a bit x-centered (focused primarily on a single explanation)
- Evidence from qualitative details of the single case.

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *What is the effect of bureaucratic professionalism on (a specific type of performance) across EU member states?*
 - Primarily x-centered (focused primarily on one explanatory variable) but also a bit y-centered (explaining variation across countries in the y of interest).
- Expectations for both main variable and control variables are grounded in existing literature.
- Evidence from panel (across countries and time) regression model.

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *Why did (a specific country) carry out a relatively open participatory policymaking dialogue (in a specific setting)?*
- Tests between two clearly-developed hypotheses emphasizing “informing policy” and “regime strengthening.”
- Evidence primarily from qualitative analysis of politician’s speeches, as well as other relevant details from the case.
- Y-centered question
- Single case study

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *What is the effect of fiscal decentralization on service delivery in (a specific country)?*
- Quantitative study, mostly x-centered: Focused on finding out the effect of one key variable, but also needs to control for other relevant factors.
- Develops different possible theoretical explanations for why we might expect different types of effects of fiscal decentralization.
- Quantitative data across multiple provinces and multiple years.

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *What is the effect of gender of high-level administrators (at a specific government level in a specific country) on the gender attitudes of lower-level employees?*
- X-centered
- Develops different theoretically-motivated reasons why we might expect different types of effects.
- Tested with a survey of individuals across many offices, combined with administrative data on leadership gender.

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *Why is (specific policy area) in (specific country) so much less captured by industry than in other similar settings?*
- Y-centered
- Motivated by cross-case variation, but focuses on a single case. (Good way to demonstrate “puzzling case”)
- Focused on developing and testing their own new argument (but with attention to others as well).
- Evidence from publicly-available documents from policy development in this area.

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *Which legislative proposals in (a specific country) get on the agenda to receive debate?*
- Develops several alternative hypotheses from existing literature.
- Y-centered
- Evidence from both interviews and “light” quantitative analysis – descriptive statistics but no regression model.

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *What explains US-EU differences in (specific policy area)?*
 - Needs to be under-studied enough policy area that this hasn't been done before; or to bring a novel perspective.
- Y-centered
- Classic comparative case study between two cases
- Develops alternate hypotheses from relevant literatures
- Tested using wide variety of qualitative information; focused on comparison between the two cases.

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *What is the effect of ministerial reorganization on policy collaboration (in a specific country and policy area)?*
- X-centered
- Develops explanations from literature for why we might expect different findings.
- Qualitative comparison of legislation and budgets before and after a merger, plus a survey questionnaire of policymakers (but focused on qualitative responses).

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *Why does (a specific country) maintain price controls and import restrictions in (a specific sector)?*
- Y-centered
- Single-case puzzle depends on successfully making case that the situation is indeed “puzzling”
- Tests between PET vs interest groups emphasis.
- Evidence from “light” quantitative analysis of newspaper articles, plus two case studies of potential policy change.

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *What was the impact of a local government reform (in a specific country) on fiscal autonomy?*
- X-centered
- Draws different possible expectations from existing theory/literature.
- Evidence both from qualitative details of case, and from “light” quantitative analysis of budgets before-vs-after.

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *What was the effect of Trump's election on (a specific type of agency practice) in US federal agencies?*
- X-centered
- Draws from theory/literature to establish different possible theoretical expectations
- Evidence from “light” quantitative analysis of agency metrics plus “mini-cases” of several agencies.

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *Why did policymakers in (a specific country) pay so much attention to international rankings?*
- Y-centered
 - Single case depends on making the case that this is indeed “puzzling”
- Uses MSA to test between roles of different streams.
- Qualitative case study based on primary and secondary documents plus in-depth interviews.

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *What explains variation in (specific policy) across provinces in (specific country)?*
- Y-centered
 - Explaining subnational variation
- Quantitative regression analysis, different independent variables capture different potential explanations relevant in existing literature.

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *Why did city A reform (a specific type of) regulations while city B didn't?*
- Y-centered
 - Explaining variation across two cases, after establishing that they are sufficiently comparable.
- Uses combination of qual and quant data to test a series of hypotheses drawn from broader literature, e.g. PET, incrementalism, ACF, costs of reform, interest group strength.

Examples! (summarized and partially obscured)

- *Why did (a specific country at a specific time) adopt EIA legislation ?*
- Y-centered
 - Establishes that the event of interest is puzzling given what we might have expected.
- Uses qualitative information (from documents, media, leg debates) to test different hypotheses, focusing primarily on cross-nat lesson-drawing and political control.

Questions?